

[Return to Search](#)

Islam and clan organization among the Hausa

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Document Type: Article

Original Page: 203

Culture (OWC): [Hausa \(MS12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1938-1939

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Nigeria

Section Title(S)

THE INSTITUTION OF THE CLAN AMONG THE PAGAN HAUSA

The Hausa, both pagan and Moslem, distinguish between relationship on the father's side (ná wandó[unknown], "of the trouser") and on the mother's side (ná záne[unknown], "of the woman's cloth"). As we have seen, when questioned concerning the origin of the clan name, the most usual reply is that there must have been a clan ancestor in the male line who gave his name to the clan at its founding. However unlikely as an actual theory of the origin of the clan designations, we have here a strong native affirmation of the common origin in the patrilineal line of all the members of a particular clan.

[611](#)
[Rules Of Descent](#)

[618](#)
[Localized Kin Groups](#)

The exogamous rule is satisfied by marriage with a member of any other clan. No attention is paid in this matter to the tribal groupings to which the clan belongs, and the marriage takes place occasionally between couples who live at a great distance from each other. The exogamous rule is said to be ignored by the clan of the Yán Má[unknown]yú[unknown], "children of the witches," who, because of the unsavory nature of their occupation (which is supposed to be inherited with the mother's milk), are reduced to endogamy.

[582](#)
[Regulation Of Marriage](#)

[618](#)
[Localized Kin Groups](#)

Although any marriage into another clan is possible, the cross-cousin marriage between a man and his mother's brother's daughter has a definite preferred status. This is expressed by saying that a man should take a wife from the same place his father did.

582
Regulation Of
Marriage

618
Localized Kin Groups

The emphasis on cross-cousin marriage has its correlate in the joking relationship between cross-cousins. Although the kinship terminology,⁷ which is in general of the merging type, gives no special recognition to cross-cousins as opposed to parallel cousins, cross cousins, whether of the same or opposite sex, are said to be 'abó[unknown]kán wa[unknown]sá[unknown], "playmates." This is a relationship also found between grandparents and grandchildren and in some other instances to be discussed later. Among the liberties allowed between 'abó[unknown]kán wa[unknown]sá[unknown] who are cross-cousins is the taking of property without compensation. It is the privilege of the offspring of the sister to take property from the offspring of the brother, who are supposed to be too proud to retaliate because of their superior position. Traditionally, the time when this should occur is during the month of Muharram, the first of the Mohammedan year, the 10th day of which is an important festival in all Moslem countries. Coincident with this festival, the inferior cross-cousin may take nine cowrie shells from his superior relative.

113
Bibliographies In
Sources

602
Kin Relationships

603
Grandparents And
Grandchildren

605
Cousins

618
Localized Kin Groups

This usage is extended to pairs of clans between whom there is traditional intermarriage. All clans have at least one partner in such a relationship, occasionally ■ 204 several, and a pair of clans thus connected are said to be 'abó[unknown]kán wa[unknown]sá[unknown] to each other. Of the two clans, one is said to be *d'an wâ*[unknown], "son of the older brother," and the other one *d'án k'ánwa*[unknown], "son of the younger sister"; and any member of the latter clan, as the inferior, is privileged to take from any member of the former. However, both clans as a rule claim to be superior and refuse to take from each other. In another formulation, the members of the superior clan claim that their joking partners are descended from one of their slaves in former times who married the daughter of their clan ancestor. Here again each clan claims that the other is descended from one of their slaves. One clan at least, the *K^w áryá*[unknown]*wá*[unknown], state that they are descendants of a Baribari (Kanuri) slave, the great-great-grandfather of the present mature generation, who married a daughter of a member of the *Zá*[unknown]*fá*[unknown]*wá*[unknown] clan whom the *K^w áryá*[unknown]*wá*[unknown] consider their superior cross-cousins.

602
Kin Relationships

605
Cousins

618
Localized Kin Groups

For Hausa kinship terminology see J. H. Greenberg, *The Influence of Islam on a Sudanese Religion* (Monographs, American Ethnological Society, no. 10, 1946), p. 20.

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